

Which type of thematic analysis is right for your study?

Three approaches. One spectrum. A clear framework for choosing the one that fits your research.

Coding Reliability TA

"small q"

Codebook / Coding Frame TA

"medium q"

Reflexive TA

"big Q"

← STRUCTURED · CONSISTENT · CATEGORICAL

INTERPRETIVE · REFLEXIVE · GENERATIVE →

AT A GLANCE

Three approaches — each designed for a different analytic purpose

No approach is better or worse. The right one depends on what your study is trying to do, what role you play as a researcher, and what counts as quality in your context.

CODING RELIABILITY TA

Consistency is central

"small q" qualitative research

AIM	Organise and summarise what participants said
THEMES	Topic summaries and categories
CODING	Predefined, structured, consistent
ROLE	Neutral application of codes
QUALITY	Inter-rater reliability, replicability

CODEBOOK / CODING FRAME TA

Structure meets interpretation

"medium q" qualitative research

AIM	Map patterned responses across cases or groups
THEMES	Patterned responses across the dataset
CODING	Shared framework, may evolve
ROLE	Interpretive within a structure
QUALITY	Transparency, auditability

REFLEXIVE TA

Interpretation is central

"big Q" qualitative research

AIM	Interpret meanings, interrogate the data
THEMES	Patterns of shared meaning you generate
CODING	Flexible, evolving, interpretive
ROLE	Active, reflexive meaning-maker
QUALITY	Reflexivity, depth, coherent choices

SIDE BY SIDE

How the three approaches differ across five key dimensions

Read across a row to compare how each approach handles the same question.
Read down a column to build a complete picture of one approach.

DIMENSION	CODING RELIABILITY TA	CODEBOOK / CODING FRAME TA	REFLEXIVE TA
ANALYTIC AIM	Organise and summarise	Map patterns across cases	Interpret and interrogate

DIMENSION	CODING RELIABILITY TA	CODEBOOK / CODING FRAME TA	REFLEXIVE TA
	Categorise data consistently; topic coverage matters most	Compare groups, support applied or policy insights	Understand meaning, experience, or assumptions
WHAT A THEME IS	A topic summary What participants talked about; a category	A patterned response What shows up across cases, groups, or settings	A pattern of shared meaning Actively generated through interpretation — not discovered
HOW CODING WORKS	Predefined framework Codes developed early; applied consistently across coders	Shared codebook Developed collaboratively; may evolve during analysis	Flexible and evolving Coding generates insight; it is not fixed in advance
RESEARCHER ROLE	Neutral applier Subjectivity is managed or minimised	Structured interpreter Judgement used within an agreed framework	Reflexive meaning-maker Subjectivity is a resource — engaged, not removed
QUALITY MARKERS	Reliability Inter-rater agreement, consistency, replicability	Transparency Auditability, traceable analytic decisions	Reflexivity Interpretive depth, coherent analytic choices
TYPICAL CONTEXT	Multi-coder studies Funders or journals expect reliability markers	Applied and team research Policy, evaluation, or practice-based projects	PhD or interpretive research Solo or small-team; meaning and experience as focus

APPROACH 1

Coding Reliability
 Thematic Analysis

"small q" qualitative research

- Multiple coders working consistently
- Codebook developed early and fixed

- Inter-rater reliability as quality check
- Themes as categories or topic summaries
- Researcher subjectivity minimised
- Replicability valued

Coding Reliability TA is designed for studies where consistency is the central value. It is most often used when multiple coders need to apply the same codes in the same way, when qualitative data are being categorised systematically, and when funders, ethics boards, or journals expect reliability as a quality marker.

In this approach, the researcher is expected to apply codes as consistently and neutrally as possible. Subjectivity is treated as something to manage or reduce — not a resource to draw on. Frameworks are typically developed before or early in the analysis, then applied rigorously to the data.

THEMES ARE

Topic summaries — categories that organise what participants talked about

CODING IS

Systematic application of a predefined or early-developed codebook

RIGOUR LOOKS LIKE

Inter-rater reliability scores, structured processes, documented consistency

BEST SUITED TO

Multi-coder studies; mixed methods; contexts requiring replicability

Watch for: If you are using inter-rater reliability while claiming to do Reflexive TA, that is a mismatch. These approaches are not compatible. Reflexive TA explicitly does not use coding reliability as a quality marker.

APPROACH 2

Codebook / Coding Frame Thematic Analysis

"medium q" qualitative research

- Shared coding framework across the team
- Codebook may evolve during analysis
- Applied, policy, or evaluation research
- Themes as patterned responses across cases
- Interpretation used within a structure

- Auditability and transparency valued

Codebook or Coding Frame TA sits between highly structured and highly interpretive approaches. It is designed for studies where a shared framework is useful but interpretation still matters. The codebook may begin with a predefined structure or develop inductively from the data — and it can be refined as analysis progresses.

This approach is common in applied, policy-focused, evaluative, and team-based research. Researchers use interpretation and professional judgement, but within an agreed analytic structure. Transparency and a traceable decision trail are what make this approach rigorous.

THEMES ARE

Patterned responses mapped across cases, groups, or the dataset

CODING IS

A shared, structured process that may adapt as analysis develops

RIGOUR LOOKS LIKE

Clarity, transparency, auditable analytic decisions, consistency of process

BEST SUITED TO

Team research, applied settings, evaluation and policy projects

Watch for: If your coding is entirely flexible with no shared structure, or if you are working solo on interpretive or conceptual research, Reflexive TA may be a better fit. If you are seeking inter-rater reliability as your main quality marker, Coding Reliability TA is more appropriate.

APPROACH 3

Reflexive Thematic Analysis

"big Q" qualitative research

- Coding is flexible and evolving throughout
- No fixed codebook; no inter-rater reliability
- Themes generated, not discovered
- Researcher reflexivity is built in, not added on
- PhD, thesis, or theory-informed research
- Interpretive depth as the quality standard

Reflexive TA is designed for studies where interpretation and the researcher's analytic role are central. Themes are not inputs into analysis — they are outputs. They are patterns of shared meaning that you actively generate through deep, sustained engagement with the data. They are not discovered; they are constructed.

In Reflexive TA, the researcher's subjectivity is not a problem to manage — it is a resource to engage with thoughtfully. Reflexivity is not an add-on or a quality statement at the end of a methods section; it is woven through the entire analytic process. This approach does not use coding reliability, consensus coding, or fixed codebooks as markers of quality.

THEMES ARE

Patterns of shared meaning actively generated through interpretation

CODING IS

A flexible, evolving, interpretive process — coding produces insight

RIGOUR LOOKS LIKE

Reflexivity, interpretive depth, coherent and clearly explained analytic choices

BEST SUITED TO

PhD research, solo interpretive studies, experience and meaning-focused work

Watch for: If you are using a fixed codebook, seeking inter-rater reliability, or working in an applied context that requires an auditable process, Reflexive TA is not appropriate — even if it sounds appealing or is commonly cited in your field.

COMMON PITFALLS

Signs your approach needs clarification

These are not signs your study is flawed. They are signs your analytic logic needs to be made more explicit — and can usually be resolved through a clearer articulation of your choices.

MISMATCH

Using inter-rater reliability while claiming to do Reflexive TA

Inter-rater reliability is appropriate for Coding Reliability TA — it is explicitly not a quality marker in Reflexive TA, where researcher subjectivity is a resource, not a problem.

MISMATCH

Calling themes "patterns of shared meaning" but treating them as topic summaries

Language borrowed from Reflexive TA with practices from Coding Reliability TA creates incoherence that reviewers and examiners will notice.

MISMATCH

Using a fixed codebook while describing coding as reflexive and organic

A fixed codebook is a feature of Coding Reliability or Codebook TA. Reflexive TA coding is flexible and evolving — the two are not compatible in the same study.

MISMATCH

Claiming inductive analysis while applying a predefined framework

Inductive and deductive are not the same as flexible and structured. Clarify whether your framework was developed from the data or applied to it.

MISMATCH

Receiving conflicting advice from supervisors or reviewers

This often means different people are assuming different TA approaches. Making your approach explicit — and why it fits your study — usually resolves the confusion.

MISMATCH

Feeling unsure how to justify your analytic choices in writing

If you cannot complete the sentence below, your approach likely needs clarification — not more data or more codes.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Can you complete this sentence?

When you can write this clearly, your approach is coherent. If you get stuck, that is useful information — it points to exactly what needs clarification.

I am using type of TA to analytic aim because reason it fits. This means I understand themes as definition, coding as function, and quality as criteria.

CODING RELIABILITY TA

"I am using Coding Reliability TA to systematically categorise participant responses because consistency across coders is essential for our multi-site study. This means I understand themes as categories, coding as a structured and consistent process, and quality as inter-rater reliability."

CODEBOOK / CODING FRAME TA

"I am using Codebook TA to map patterned responses across policy contexts because the research needs to be auditable and usable by stakeholders. This means I understand themes as patterned responses, coding as a shared evolving framework, and quality as transparency and traceable decisions."

REFLEXIVE TA

"I am using Reflexive TA to interpret the meaning participants make of their experiences because conceptual insight matters more than categorisation. This means I understand themes as patterns of shared meaning I generate, coding as a flexible interpretive process, and quality as reflexivity and depth."

Not sure which approach fits your study?

Use the interactive decision tool to work through four questions about your research — and get a clear recommendation with the reasoning behind it. Or download the full PDF guide for a complete walkthrough with congruence checks and further reading.

[Try the decision tool →](#)[Download PDF](#)